

CJ PHILIP

A Tri Layer System



First published by CJ Philip Productions 2026

Copyright © 2026 by CJ Philip

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, scanning, or otherwise without written permission from the publisher. It is illegal to copy this book, post it to a website, or distribute it by any other means without permission.

CJ Philip asserts the moral right to be identified as the author of this work.

First edition

This book was professionally typeset on Reedsy.

Find out more at reedsy.com

A Three-Tier System: How I Punctuate Thought, Speech, and Story

Punctuation is the foundation of a story. Truly there is no better tool at an authors disposal than punctuation for enhancing the clarity of their writing. It is the difference between “Let’s go eat Grandma.” and “Let’s go eat, Grandma.” For those who didn’t understand the difference, the first is cannibalism the second is inviting Grandma to the dinner table.

But while it is fascinating to discuss the intricacies of comma placement. Today I want to discuss three main layers of my own punctuation system, specifically: differentiating Dialogue, Thought and Perspective.

What do I mean by this? Well I’m glad you asked reader.

Let’s begin with our first Topic.

* * *

Dialogue & Thought.

Dialogue and thought? Okay? What about them? Well dear reader, have you ever realised the fact that a page can have at least three different kinds of voice? There is what a character

says out loud. This is dialogue, or external monologue. Then there is that they think to themselves. This is thought or internal monologue. Finally there is what the narrative itself tells you. This is just the prose or main body of the story.

The Issue that can arise is that if one is not careful when writing these three distinct voices, is that they may start to blur together in your mind. Essentially it will turn into a massive wall of grey. This is particularly an issue if said reader has a visual or reading Impairment such as Dyslexia.

As a reader and aspiring author who has dyslexia myself I have experienced this first hand. Many a time I will find myself confusing what the prose told me for a thought or a thought for dialogue. Due to this when I started to write my own Fantasy series - The Alvora Chronicles - I wanted to develop a system to better distinguish the three.

The First part of this system is Dialogue/ External monologue.

This is perhaps the easiest part of the system to explain dear reader, because I simply use “|” double quote marks for my dialogue. It is a standard and I found no real reason to go against it. It’s clean, it’s visual and it gets the point across well, “Hey someone is speaking.” I saw no real need to reinvent the wheel.

The Second Part of this System is Thought/ Internal monologue.

This is where I feel I must explain myself a little more clearly. In my system I use ‘|’ single quote marks alongside *italics*, to convey thought. The reason I do this is twofold. Firstly, it helps to differentiate the thoughts from narrative text and Dialogue. Secondly, using this system for thoughts removes the need for the redundant **I thought** tags.

Allow me to demonstrate this with a quick example.

I looked Susan up and down, *she’s got a nice dress*, I
thought. She saw me staring.

This works, but that thought reads as part of the prose doesn’t it, at least until you get to the obligatory I thought tag at the end. By comparison using my system it would read like so:

I looked Susan up and down, ‘*She’s got a nice dress.*’
She saw me looking.

It’s a small difference of course but the ‘|’ single quotes signal that this is a distinct voice than the prose, while removing the I thought tag from the equation. Of course this system generally works better if you are telling the story from first person, where that distinction is necessary, third person I believe does sound awkward with this system.

David looked Susan up and down, '*She's got a nice dress.*' She saw him staring.

That being said however for **third person** I would still recommend using the '|' Single quotes and Italics to separate thought from prose visually.

David looked Susan up and down, '*She's got a nice dress,*' he thought. She saw him staring.

Of course he thought isn't the only option for a tag here, but that's not the point of this Essay. Maybe I'll write one on that one day. Depends on what my ADHD decides to Hyperfocus on next I suppose. Anyway on to the next Topic.

* * *

POV

Now I will explain how I differentiate between different Points of View (POVS) in the chapter title and explain my reasoning behind the system. I promise there **is** a method to my madness. There are two main ways that authors traditionally differentiate character's POV in titles.

The First of these methods is when the character's name is attached as a label to the end. For Example.

7

The Battle at the Docks

— David —

This is a reliable and effective method. It clearly states which character's head we will be inhabiting in this chapter. However that being said it is a little frustrating having to read the character's name in the heading explicitly. Especially if said character has **multiple** chapters in a row. It can bog down the reading experience somewhat. However it remains my favourite - of the standard methods - way to mark the chapters.

Another way in which this signalling is done is to include the character in the chapter title itself. For example

7

David battles at the Docks

I'm sure dear reader you can understand what my issue is with this method. Right? Well if not let's quickly check what a table of contents might look like if one were to use this method.

1 - David receives a vision

2 - Susan's Choice

3 - A tough decision for David

4 - David's trial

5 - Susan leaves

6 - A sign for David

7 - David battles at the Docks.

Notice how rather than letting the titles stand on their own they are being bogged down by shoving the character's name into them. What I would internalise if I read that would be. '*David*,

Susan, David, David, Susan, David, David.’ Which aside from being repetitive would make the text itself become a barrier to entry.

Now there are certainly examples of authors who have made these two systems work. For an excellent example of the label system in action from an author who I hold a lot of respect for I would point to Rick Riordan’s heroes of Olympus series. In this series Riordan set himself a tremendous challenge of balancing seven different POV characters. (Which I would not recommend to an inexperienced writer) Each chapter is styled as shown below.

(Chapter title.
— Character X –)

These Labels work in this case because as I said he has to balance seven different characters.

However For my work I chose to not follow the Label method, or the Name in title method. Instead I simplified it down to a visual signal. In my work I select a symbol to represent each of my characters. Using David and Susan as an example (Who are not characters in my books just in case any of you thought this was a spoiler.) Let’s assume David is a swordsman. He duel-wields short swords, and then we assume Susan is perhaps a witch. So she uses a wand. Drawing from the titles above I would have.

7
⌘ The Battle at the Docks

Or in the case of a Susan chapter.

5

The Departure

This simple visual marker signals to the reader whose head we will be inhabiting without creating unnecessary friction. Of course this system does have its drawbacks. Namely the inherent lack of text symbols available, especially the saddening lack of black and white text symbols available. Unfortunately many of the text symbols which would have been ideal for this have been updated to be colourful emoji style symbols. However I believe this issue can be fixed in post/before publication. Similarly the general lack of symbols can be fixed by replacing the symbol later with a custom one. This is an issue I take with many word processors including the one I am using to write this very Essay - Reedsy - the issue being that there is no mechanism for the creation of custom text symbols. Be it for fictional languages, chapter heading or showcasing the symbol to the reader there is no method for adding a glyph, rune or symbol into these platforms.

* * *

In conclusion my dear readers I developed this system purely because I found the default formatting to be difficult to parse at times. I make no claims about this system being the best way of doing things but I have found it useful for me when writing and reading my own passages. Furthermore I believe that authors **should** be able to play around with formatting more often than they currently do.

Thank you for reading this Essay.

A TRI LAYER SYSTEM

CJ Philip